Committee: United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC)

Topic: The Role of Technology in Facilitating Transnational Crime

Chair: Klea Gashi

Table of Contents

1. Introduction

2. Definition of Essential Terms

3. General Context

4. Key Parties Involved and Their Perspectives

5. Questions to Consider

6. Suggested Resources

7. Conclusion

8. Bibliography

1. Introduction

In today's increasingly connected world, criminal organizations no longer need to cross physical borders to operate internationally. A fraudulent investment message can reach a victim thousands of kilometers away, stolen personal information can be sold through online marketplaces, and illegally obtained funds can move between financial systems within minutes. Although transnational crime existed long before the digital age, technological developments have significantly changed how criminal networks operate, allowing them to expand their reach, accelerate their activities, and coordinate across borders with greater ease (UNODC, Transnational Organized Crime).

As technology continues to develop, so do the methods used by organized criminal groups. Social media platforms may be exploited to recruit trafficking victims, encrypted communication services and darknet marketplaces can facilitate illegal drug transactions, and AI can be used to create increasingly convincing scams and impersonations. Meanwhile, cryptocurrencies and other virtual assets can enable the movement of illicit funds across borders, although some transactions remain traceable. These developments have contributed to the growing connections between cyber enabled fraud , money laundering, and organized crime, particularly in Southeast Asia (UNODC, Transnational Organized Crime; INTERPOL).

However, these consequences of technology facilitated crime extend far beyond financial losses. Victims may face identity theft, exploitation, or even trafficking into criminal operations, while the profits generated can strengthen organized crime networks and corruption. At the same time, technology offers valuable opportunities for law enforcement through digital investigations, financial intelligence, and international information sharing. The challenge therefore lies in addressing its misuse without compromising privacy, human rights, or the benefits of technological progress (OHCHR, A Wicked Problem; UNODC, The Nexus).

For the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime, addressing these challenges requires stronger international cooperation, effective criminal justice systems, and greater protection for victims. This report examines the role of technology in facilitating transnational crime, the legal

frameworks addressing it, and the perspectives of key stakeholders, providing delegates with a foundation for developing practical and internationally coordinated solutions.

2. Definition of Essential Terms

a) Transnational Organized Crime: Criminal activity involving more than one country through its planning, execution, participants, or consequences. Under the UNTOC, a crime may be transnational even if committed in one country, provided it has significant connections to another

b) Organized Crime Group: A structured group of three or more individuals acting together over time to commit serious crimes for financial or material benefit. Such groups do not necessarily require formal leadership or defined roles

c) Cyber-Enabled Crime: Traditional crimes, such as fraud, drug trafficking, and money laundering, that are facilitated, expanded, or made more efficient through digital technology.

d) Virtual Assets: Digital representation of value that can be electronically transferred, traded, or used for payment or investment. Cryptocurrencies are one example, and their misuse can facilitate money laundering

e) Social Engineering Fraud: Fraud in which criminals manipulate people's trust to obtain money or confidential information, often through deceptive emails, messages, impersonations, or other online communication

f) Money Laundering: The process of disguising the illegal origin of money or assets obtained through crime, often using businesses, financial institutions, or digital transactions to make them appear legitimate.

g) Electronic Evidence: Data stored or transmitted electronically that may be used in an investigation or legal proceeding, such as messages, transaction records, account information, or

digital files. Accessing and sharing such evidence across borders can raise legal, privacy, and sovereignty concerns.

3. General Context

The Transformation of Criminal Networks

Technological advancements have significantly changed how criminal organizations operate, allowing them to coordinate activities across borders without physically being present. Through smartphones, social media, cloud services, and international payment systems, different groups can divide responsibilities, from stealing personal data and contacting victims to transferring and laundering illicit funds. Criminal services can also be rented or outsourced, allowing networks to operate without every participant knowing the others involved (UNODC, Transnational Organized Crime; Europol).

These networks can quickly adapt by moving between platforms, recruiting accomplices internationally, and targeting victims in different countries. However, traditional elements such as trafficking routes, drug shipments, and corruption remain essential to many operations. This demonstrates how digital and physical criminal activities increasingly overlap, making it necessary to address cybercrime as part of the broader challenge of organized crime (UNODC, The Nexus).

Online Fraud, Identity Theft and AI-Assisted Deception

Digital platforms have made online fraud increasingly sophisticated. Criminals use fake investment websites, bank impersonations, identity theft, and deceptive online relationships to obtain money. Artificial intelligence further enables realistic fake profiles, automated messages, and synthetic voices. INTERPOL's 2026 assessment highlights the growing connection between AI assisted fraud, organized crime, and scam centers (INTERPOL; UNODC, Transnational Organized Crime).

The consequences affect individuals, businesses, and public institutions through stolen identities, fraudulent invoices, and redirected payments. Investigations become difficult when perpetrators, victims, and financial services operate across different jurisdictions. Effective responses therefore require public awareness, early detection, international evidence sharing, and mechanisms to recover stolen assets (INTERPOL; U.S. Department of Justice).

However, AI is not inherently criminal. Member States must consider how to address its misuse without unnecessarily restricting legitimate innovation, communication, or access to digital services.

Cryptocurrencies and the Movement of Illicit Proceeds

Financial technology has introduced faster methods of transferring money internationally. Although cryptocurrencies and virtual assets have legitimate uses, criminal organizations may exploit unregulated platforms and weaknesses in financial supervision to transfer illicit proceeds. FATF recommendation 15 establishes risk based standards for virtual assets, but its July 2026 assessment identified continued differences in national implementation (FATF).

Nevertheless, not all cryptocurrencies transactions are anonymous or illegal. Public blockchain transactions can often be traced, although identifying individuals may require international cooperation. Since criminals may combine digital payments with cash and informal banking, effective responses should strengthen financial intelligence, asset recovery, and regulation while protecting privacy (FATF).

Drug Trafficking and Illicit Online Markets

Technology has changed how illegal drugs are advertised, purchased, and distributed. Social media, encrypted messaging applications, and darknet marketplaces allow criminals to reach customers internationally, often using virtual assets for payment. According to UNODC's

World Drug Report 2026, estimated darknet marketplace sales, primarily involving drugs, reached approximately US 2.5 billion dollars in 2025. However, this figure does not represent total global drug sales, and social media remains another major channel for online drug transactions (UNODC, World Drug Report 2026).

Despite digital developments, drugs must still be physically transported through postal services, couriers, and international trade routes. Combating this activity therefore requires combining digital investigations and financial tracking with customs enforcement and international intelligence sharing (UNODC, World Drug Report 2026). This also highlights the importance of cooperation between police, customs authorities, financial investigators, and online platforms, since no single agency can address every part of a transnational criminal network.

Human Trafficking, Online Recruitment and Forced Criminality

Digital platforms allow traffickers to recruit and exploit victims internationally, often through fraudulent job advertisements. UN Human Rights has documented cases in Southeast Asia where trafficked individuals are forced to participate in online scams. Its February 2026 report emphasizes human rights protection and the non-punishment principle for trafficking victims (OHCHR, A Wicked Problem; OHCHR, Online Scam Operations).

Individuals involved in scams may therefore be victims rather than willing perpetrators. Authorities must identify and protect individuals who have been trafficked or coerced into criminal operations, while holding organizers, recruiters, and financiers accountable. UNODC also highlights the links between trafficking, online fraud, and illicit financial networks (UNODC, *Transnational Organized Crime*; OHCHR, *A Wicked Problem*).

International Legal Framework and UNODC's Mandate

The United Nations Convention against Transnational Organized Crime (2000) provides a framework for combating organized crime through criminalization, extradition, and mutual legal assistance. Its Trafficking in Persons Protocol addresses exploitation, while the UN Convention against Corruption covers corruption linked to criminal activities. UNODC supports Member States in implementing these agreements (UNODC, Definition in the Organized Crime Convention; UNODC, The Nexus).

The United Nations Convention against Cybercrime, adopted on 24 December 2024 under General Assembly resolution 79/243, opened for signature in Hanoi in October 2025. It addresses technology-related offences and international cooperation in obtaining electronic evidence. As of 28 September 2026, it had not entered into force. Under Article 65(1), entry into force requires 40 qualifying ratifications, acceptances, approvals, or accessions, followed by 90 days (United Nations Treaty Collection).

The Budapest Convention and its 24/7 cooperation network also support international investigations, while UNODC's SHERLOC Electronic Evidence Hub provides legal guidance and training. However, as of 27 October 2026, the Convention had not entered into force. Under Article 65(1), it requires 40 qualifying instruments of ratification, acceptance, approval, or accession to be deposited before it can enter into force 90 days later (United Nations Treaty Collection, United Nations Convention against Cybercrime: Status and Text).

4. Key Parties Involved and their Perspectives

List countries, organizations, and individuals involved, along with a summary of their roles and views on the issue.

a) International Organizations

i. **United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime:** UNODC supports governments in combating organized crime, trafficking, corruption, and cybercrime through legal assistance,

investigative training, and international cooperation. Its role focuses on strengthening criminal justice systems rather than directly conducting police operations (UNODC, Electronic Evidence Hub; UNODC, The Nexus). UNODC also supports countries with imited inevstigative resources through training, technical assistance, and the sharing of good practices.

ii. **International Criminal Police Organizations:** INTERPOL facilitates cooperation between national police forces, supports international investigations, and combats financial and cybercrime. Its 2026 fraud assessment highlights connections between online scams, human trafficking, and organized criminal networks (INTERPOL).

iii. **Financial Action Task Force:** FATF establishes international standards to combat money laundering and illicit financial flows. It promotes risk based regulation of virtual assets, financial supervision, and international cooperation to trace and recover criminal proceeds (FATF)

iv. **Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights:** OHCHR documents human rights abuses linked to technology facilitated crime, particularly trafficking into scam operations. It emphasized victim protection, accountability, and safeguards for individuals forced into criminal activities (OHCHR, A Wicked Problem).

b) States and Regional Perspectives

i. **United States of America:** The US prioritizes combating cross-border cybercrime, online fraud, and crypto-related financial crimes. In June 2026, the Department of Justice announced a coordinated operation that disabled fraudulent accounts and froze over 3.8 million US dollars in suspected criminal cryptocurrency proceeds, demonstrating its focus on financial tracing and public-private cooperation (U.S. Department of Justice).

ii. **People's Republic of China:** China has strengthened cross border cooperation against online and telecommunications fraud, particularly with Myanmar and Thailand. In July 2026, Chinese authorities announced plans for broader international anti-fraud cooperation, emphasizing coordinated law enforcement while maintaining national sovereignty (State Council Information Office).

iii. **Countries of Southeast Asia:** Several southeast asian countries face challenges involving online scam compounds, trafficking networks, and illicit financial services. UNODC and OHCHR have documented connections between cyber-enabled fraud, underground banking, and forced criminality. Responses vary among countries, highlighting the need for stronger regional cooperation and victim protection (UNODC, Transnational Organized Crime; OHCHR, A Wicked Problem).

iv. **European Union:** The EU emphasises coo[eration between law enforcement and judicial authorities, cross-border access to electronic evidence, and safeguards for privacy and fundamental rights. Its approach provides a useful perspective on how international investigations can be made more efficient while remaining subject to legal protections. (European Commission, Cross-Border Access to Electronic Evidence).

c) Non-State Stakeholders

i. **Technology Platforms and Telecommunications Providers:** Technology companies can help identify fraudulent activities, preserve electronic evidence, and cooperate with law enforcement. However, such cooperation must follow legal procedures and protect users' privacy and personal information (UNODC, Electronic Evidence Hub; European Commission).

ii. **Banks, Payment Firms and Virtual Asset Service Providers:** Financial institutions play an important role in detecting suspicious transactions, preventing money laundering, and assisting with asset recovery. Cooperation with authorities can help trace illicit funds, while

financial regulations must remain proportionate and risk based (FATF; U.S. Department of Justice).

5. Questions to Consider

1. How can Member States distinguish cyber dependent crimes from traditional crimes facilitated by technology?
2. What measures can UNODC recommend to prevent AI generated scams and online fraud without restricting legitimate technology use?
3. How can governments prosecute organizers of online scram operations while protecting trafficked or coerced victims?
4. How can countries improve cross border electronic evidence shaking while protecting privacy and legal rights?
5. How can governments strengthen investigations while criminals, victims, and financial transactions span multiple countries?
6. How can Member States prevent cryptocurrency related money laundering while supporting financial innovation and privacy?
7. What responsibilities should technology platforms, banks, and financial service providers have in preventing transnational crime?
8. How can international organizations help developing countries improve their technology and investigative capabilities?
9. What safeguards can prevent cybercrime enforcement from violating human rights or enabling unlawful surveillance?
10. How can UNODC, INTERPOL, and national authorities improve international cooperation, asset recovery, and victim protection>

6. Suggested Research Resources

a) UNODC — Transnational Organized Crime and the Convergence of Cyber-Enabled Fraud, Underground Banking and Technological Innovation in Southeast Asia (2024)

https://www.unodc.org/roseap/uploads/documents/Publications/2024/TOC_Convergence_Report_2024.pdf

b) INTERPOL — Global Financial Fraud Threat Assessment (2026)
https://www.interpol.int/en/News-and-Events/News/2026/INTERPOL-report-warns-of-increasingly-sophisticated-global-financial-fraud-threat

c) UN Treaty Collection — United Nations Convention against Cybercrime: Status and Text
https://treaties.un.org/pages/ViewDetails.aspx?chapter=18&mtdsg_no=XVIII-16&src=TREATY

d) UNODC SHERLOC — Electronic Evidence Hub
https://sherloc.unodc.org/cld/en/st/evidence/electronic-evidence-hub.html

e) UNODC — Global Report on Trafficking in Persons 2024 (full report)
https://digitallibrary.un.org/record/4069246?v=pdf

f) OHCHR — "A Wicked Problem": Trafficking into Cyber Scam Operations in South-East Asia (2026)
https://bangkok.ohchr.org/reports/wicked-problem-seeking-human-rights-based-solutions-trafficking-cyber-scam-operations

g) FATF — Seventh Targeted Update on Virtual Assets and Virtual-Asset Service Providers (2026)
https://www.fatf-gafi.org/en/publications/Fatfrecommendations/targeted-updated-virtualassets-vasps-2026.html

h) UNODC — World Drug Report 2026 Data Portal
https://data.unodc.org/wdr2026search

i) Council of Europe — 24/7 Network under the Budapest Convention
https://www.coe.int/en/web/cybercrime/24/7-network-new

j) Human Rights Watch — Joint Statement on the Signing of the UN Convention on Cybercrime (2025)
https://www.hrw.org/news/2025/10/24/joint-statement-on-the-signing-of-the-un-convention-on-cybercrime

7. Conclusion

Technology has significantly transformed transnational crime, enabling criminal organizations to expand their activities through online fraud, human trafficking, illicit trade, and money laundering. As highlighted by UNODC, INTERPOL, and Europol, AI and digital platforms have made criminal operations increasingly complex, while traditional trafficking and distribution networks remain essential (UNODC, Transnational Organized Crime; Europol).

Addressing these challenges requires stronger international cooperation, effective law enforcement, financial regulation, and victim protection. Frameworks such as the UN Convention against Transnational Crime and the Budapest Convention provide important foundations, while the UN Cybercrime Convention offers further opportunities for cooperation, although it had not entered into force as of September 2026. These efforts must respect privacy, national sovereignty, and human rights (United Nations Treaty Collection; Human Rights Watch).

UNODC delegates should focus on practical solutions that strengthen investigations, improve electronic evidence sharing, combat illicit financial flows, and protect victims. Through international cooperation and responsible policymaking, Member States can address technology-facilitated crime while ensuring accountability and respect for fundamental rights (UNODC, Electronic Evidence Hub; OHCHR, A Wicked Problem).

8. Bibliography

Council of Europe. “24/7 Network Established under the Convention on Cybercrime.” *Council of Europe*, https://www.coe.int/en/web/cybercrime/24/7-network-new.

European Commission. “Two Years of the Digital Services Act Ensuring Safer Online Spaces.”*European Commission*, 2026, https://commission.europa.eu/news-and-media/news/two-years-digital-services-act-ensuring-safer-online-spaces-2026-02-17_en.

Europol. *Steal, Deal and Repeat: How Cybercriminals Trade and Exploit Your Data*. Internet Organised Crime Threat Assessment 2025, Publications Office of the European Union, 2025, https://www.europol.europa.eu/publication-events/main-reports/steal-deal-and-repeat-how-cybercriminals-trade-and-exploit-your-data.

Financial Action Task Force (FATF). “FATF Glossary.” *FATF*, https://www.fatf-gafi.org/en/pages/fatf-glossary.html.

Seventh Targeted Update on Implementation of the FATF Standards on Virtual Assets/VASPs. FATF, 2026, https://www.fatf-gafi.org/en/publications/Fatfrecommendations/targeted-updated-virtualassets-vasps-2026.html.

Human Rights Watch. “Joint Statement on the Signing of the UN Convention on Cybercrime.” *Human Rights Watch*, 2025, https://www.hrw.org/news/2025/10/24/joint-statement-on-the-signing-of-the-un-convention-on-cybercrime.

INTERPOL. “INTERPOL Report Warns of Increasingly Sophisticated Global Financial Fraud Threat.” *INTERPOL*, 2026,

https://www.interpol.int/News-and-Events/News/2026/INTERPOL-report-warns-of-increasingly-sophisticated-global-financial-fraud-threat.

"Social Engineering Scams." *INTERPOL*, https://www.interpol.int/en/Crimes/Financial-crime/Social-engineering-scams.

Liu, Jianing. "China to Launch International Alliance against Telecom and Online Fraud." *China SCIO*, 2026, https://english.scio.gov.cn/pressroom/2026-07/24/content_118616487.html.

Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights (OHCHR). *Online Scam Operations and Trafficking into Forced Criminality in Southeast Asia: Recommendations for a Human Rights Response*. UN Human Rights, 2023, https://bangkok.ohchr.org/reports/online-scam-operations-and-trafficking-forced-criminality-southeast-asia-recommendations.

"A Wicked Problem": Seeking Human Rights-Based Solutions to Trafficking into Cyber Scam Operations in South-East Asia. UN Human Rights, 2026, https://www.bangkok.ohchr.org/reports/wicked-problem-seeking-human-rights-based-solutions-trafficking-cyber-scam-operations.

United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC). "The Crime of Trafficking in Persons." *Education for Justice*, 2019, https://www.unodc.org/e4j/en/tip-and-som/module-6/key-issues/crime-of-trafficking-in-persons.html.

"Cybercrime." *Education for Justice: Model United Nations Resource Guide*, https://www.unodc.org/e4j/ar/mun/crime-prevention/cybercrime.html.

"Definition in the Organized Crime Convention." *Education for Justice*, 2018, https://sherloc.unodc.org/cld/en/education/tertiary/organized-crime/module-1/key-issues/definition-in-convention.html.

"Definitions and Terminology." *Education for Justice*, 2019, https://www.unodc.org/e4j/fr/organized-crime/module-16/key-issues/definitions-and-terminology.html.

"Electronic Evidence Hub." *SHERLOC*, https://sherloc.unodc.org/cld/en/st/evidence/electronic-evidence-hub.html.

"Formal International Cooperation Mechanisms." *Education for Justice*, 2019, https://www.unodc.org/e4j/en/cybercrime/module-7/key-issues/formal-international-cooperation-mechanisms.html.

Global Report on Trafficking in Persons 2024. United Nations, 2024, https://digitallibrary.un.org/record/4069246.

"Money-Laundering." *Education for Justice*, 2018, https://www.unodc.org/e4j/en/organized-crime/module-4/key-issues/money-laundering.html.

The Nexus Between Cybercrime and Corruption. United Nations, 2025, https://track.unodc.org/uploads/documents/AC-hubs-and-platforms/south-east-asia/2025.10.21_The_Nexus_Between_Cybercrime_and_Corruption.pdf.

Transnational Organized Crime and the Convergence of Cyber-Enabled Fraud, Underground Banking and Technological Innovation in Southeast Asia: A Shifting Threat Landscape. United Nations, 2024, https://www.unodc.org/roseap/uploads/documents/Publications/2024/TOC_Convergence_Report_2024.pdf.

"World Drug Report 2026: List of Findings." *UNODC Data Portal*, 2026, https://data.unodc.org/wdr2026search.

United Nations Treaty Collection. “United Nations Convention against Cybercrime.” *United Nations Treaty Collection*, United Nations, 2024, https://treaties.un.org/Pages/ViewDetails.aspx?chapter=18&mtdsg_no=XVIII-16&src=TREATY.

U.S. Department of Justice. “Scam Center Strike Force Announces Results of U.S. & Private Industry ‘Disruption Week.’” *Office of Public Affairs*, 2026, https://www.justice.gov/opa/pr/scam-center-strike-force-announces-results-us-private-industry-disruption-week.